The Guardian

one stop english

Japan PM's solution to dire birth rate has already been rejected by young

Level 3: Advanced

1 Warmer

a. Discuss these questions.

1. In which countries is birth rate on the rise? How about nations with dwindling population?
2. Why do you think fewer people are choosing to have children in certain societies?
3. Why is a lower birth rate cause for concern for these governments?
4. Do you think a younger population who do not want to have children can be persuaded otherwise? If so, how?

2 Key words

a. Fill the gaps in the sentences using these key words from the text. Then complete each example sentence with the same word – you may have to change the form of the word.

crass	doomsayer	dysfunction	dystopian	flesh out	gaffe
insurmountable	shun	spearhead	strain	prong	pronouncement

1. A _____ is an official public statement.
   Most people are sceptical of politicians' _____.
2. A _____ is a failure to work well.
   A rise in violence is a sign of social _____.
3. A _____ is someone who always says that bad things will happen.
   COVID _____ *say it is wrong to think the pandemic is over.*
4. If something is _____, it is impossible to deal with successfully.
   Many earthquake victims survived seemingly _____ *odds.*
5. A _____ is any of the separate stages of a plan or activity.
   Education is part of the government's two- _____ *strategy to deal with obesity.*
6. If something is _____, it is stupid and offensive because of not being sensitive to other people's feelings.
   Jo is under scrutiny following her _____ *comments.*
7. _____ relates to the idea that life is or can be extremely bad.
   This is yet another apocalypse films set in a _____ *future.*

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8. To _____ is to lead an organized effort or activity.
   Sue-Anne currently _____ the efforts to combat littering in our neighbourhood.

9. To _____ means to deliberately avoid a person, place, or activity.
   People with diabetes are usually told to _____ sugar.

10. _____ is pressure caused by a difficult situation.
    Economic hardship can place a lot of _____ on a relationship.

11. To _____ means to add more details about something in order to make it easier to understand or imagine.
    Her tutor suggested a few ways she could _____ her essay.

12. A _____ is an embarrassing mistake that you make in public, especially one that offends or upsets someone.
    The team captain's sexist _____ went viral.

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Fumio Kishida says lifting the birth rate 'cannot wait' yet policies stick to scripts that have so far failed to address the country's population crisis

Justin McCurry

24 January 2023

1 Fumio Kishida is not given to dramatic pronouncements. But he recently issued a stark warning to the Japanese people: have more children, or risk dragging their country into the depths of dysfunction.

2 His shift in persona from bland career politician to doomsayer-in-chief is a reflection of the demographic crisis facing Japan, one of the fastest-ageing countries on earth.

3 As he said in a speech to parliament, the number of births in Japan is estimated to have sunk to below 800,000 in 2022. "Japan is on the verge of not being able to continue to function as a society," he said, adding that addressing the stubbornly low birth rate "cannot wait and cannot be postponed".

4 Overcoming Japan's demographic crisis has proved insurmountable for occupants of the Kantei – the prime minister's office – long before Kishida moved in. The population of the world's third-biggest economy has been in decline for several years and suffered a record fall of 644,000 in 2020–21, according to government data. It is expected to plummet from its current 125 million to an estimated 88 million in 2065 – a 30 per cent decline in 45 years.

5 The birth rate remains at 1.3 – the average number of children a woman will have in her lifetime – way below the 2.1 needed to keep the population stable. And the number of over-65s continues to grow – now accounting for more than 28 per cent of the population.

6 The government's response has been a two-pronged approach that combines crass entreaties to "go home and multiply" with financial incentives for couples who heed the call.

7 For all his implied warnings of a dystopian, hollowed-out Japan, Kishida is largely sticking to a script that has already been roundly rejected by young Japanese. Policies that address structural obstacles to raising the birth rate were absent from his speech. Instead, he spoke in general terms about a "child-first social economy", spearheaded by a new children and families agency.

8 Under loose plans, families will receive bigger child allowances and working parents will have access to more after-school childcare. There will be reforms that will make it easier for parents to take leave to raise families – all funded by a promised doubling in spending on children that will be finalized in June, 2023.

9 But Japan's previous efforts to encourage people to have more babies have had limited impact. Subsidies for pregnancy, childbirth and childcare have failed, while some experts complain that politicians target parents who already have children while failing to ask themselves why young people are reluctant to start families.

10 They are talking about women like Nao Imai, a university student who told the Guardian late in 2022 why the patter of tiny feet probably wouldn't be part of her future. "I used to think I would be married by 25 and a mother by 27," she said. "But when I look at my eldest sister, who has a two-year-old girl, I'm afraid to have children. When you have a child in Japan, the husband keeps working but the mother is expected to quit her job and look after the children. I just feel that it's hard to raise children – financially, mentally and physically."

11 Imai is not alone. A survey by the Nippon Foundation released just before he addressed MPs found that only 16.5% of people aged 17 to 19 believed they would get married, even though a much larger proportion wanted to do so. As the Mainichi Shimbun pointed out, the problems arise when ambitions meet economic reality.

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12 As long as successive conservative governments continue to shun immigration as part of a potential solution to chronic labour shortages and the increasing strain on funding for health and social security, the consensus is that the answers must come from within. Yet Kishida's speech was short on specifics on the long-term pressures couples say are making them think twice about having bigger families or any children at all: the cost of compulsory and higher education, the rising cost of living, poorly paid and unstable jobs for non-regular workers, and punishingly long working hours that make a healthy family life practically impossible.

13 While Japan waits for its prime minister to flesh out the details, his Liberal Democratic party colleagues send out a very different message. Taro Aso, a former prime minister with a history of gaffes, blamed the low birth rate on women who marry too late to make larger families a realistic proposition.

14 Kishida warned that Japan had reached a "now or never moment" to address its shortage of children. If experience is any guide, the smart money must be on the latter.

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3 Comprehension check

a. Choose the correct word or phrase to complete each sentence.

1. In 2022, there were **under 800,000** / **800,000 fewer** births in Japan.
2. In 2020–21, there were 644,000 fewer **births** / **people** in Japan.
3. Over the next four decades, Japan's population is expected to fall by more than **80 million** / **30 per cent**.
4. Almost a third of the population **don't have kids** / **are over 65**.
5. The government has used strong messages and **financial** / **emotional** incentives to encourage people to have (more) children.
6. The government has promised to spend **three times** / **twice** as much on children.
7. Women like Nao Imai feel it is too **challenging** / **late in life** to raise children.
8. The Japanese government has rejected **immigration** / **incentivization** as a solution to the demographic crisis.
9. Couples are inhibited by high costs of living, costly education, and a lack of **work–life balance** / **stability**.
10. Taro Aso **embarrassed** / **represented** his party when he blamed women who marry too late for the demographic crisis.
11. The author of the article thinks that Japan **will** / **won't** address its shortage of children.

4 Key language

a. Find phrases in the text that match the definitions below.

1. to make someone become involved in the most severe part of an unpleasant time, feeling or situation (paragraph 1)
2. to consider someone's advice or warning and do what they suggest (paragraph 6)
3. to do something in the same way or happen in the same way (subtitle, paragraph 7)
4. to carefully consider whether what you are planning to do is a good idea (paragraph 12)
5. used for saying that if something is not done immediately, there will not be another chance to do it in the future (paragraph 14)
6. This is what people with a lot of knowledge about this topic think. (paragraph 14)

b. Use the phrases in your own sentences.

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5 Discussion

a. Discuss these statements.

- "Having children is a personal choice. Governments should not try to influence individuals."
- "It is everyone's right to have children, so governments should provide financial support to those who do."
- "The environment cannot handle more people, so governments shouldn't encourage their citizens to start families."

6 In your own words

a. Look online for information about the countries with the highest and lowest birth rates. Find out how the governments are dealing with this.

b. Report your findings to the class.

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